

From Isolation to Interaction: Leveraging Play to Cultivate Critical Thinking and Collective Identity

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This project is to imagine new collaborative games that focus on two pillars: education and community-building. How can play be leveraged to cultivate critical thinking and collective identity in marginalised communities? Its objective is to help players develop critical thinking and logic skills on the one hand, and a cooperative spirit on the other.

Chinese jianzi is played in a circle, each person kicks the shuttlecock, if it falls to the ground, the whole group loses the game. Thus, it is the group's aim to play together in a way that will "save" the jianzi. In Mexico, toques are played in parties or bars, it consists in giving a group holding hands an electrical shock that increases until someone breaks the chain. It is a show of collective bonding. Finally, more famous and complex are Role Playing Games (RPG) where imagination and strategy appear in a game played within a crew.

Collaborative games exist in various forms and have held different meanings or sought different goals across the world. These games represent varied experiences for growth, which can foster community-building and spirit of belonging. They traditionally range from sports to creativity but can be seen as trials: building resilience by sharing challenges with friends.

This project intends to have a high impact, it means it adheres to the ITN framework, which consists in comparing cause areas based on three key factors: Neglectedness, Tractability, and Importance which are described thereafter. Firstly, marginalised groups including, but not limited to prisoners, migrants, or children in foster care, live through irregular conditions and hardships. They are often treated or viewed as "second hand citizens". In 2023, there were almost [half a million of prisoners in the EU](#), another [half million are children in residential care in Europe and Central Asia](#), and [1½ million asylum seekers in Europe](#). Taken together, the statistics of their (re)integration in society reflect systemic weaknesses:

- [post-custodial employment is extremely low](#), and [recidivism rates are high](#),
- [care leavers suffer lasting disadvantages](#) compared to their counterparts,
- [unemployment rates and social exclusion are much higher for migrants](#) than citizens

Secondly, given that [research shows how games help personal development and teach transferrable skills](#), developing collaborative games for teaching and community-building is achievable. Neglected groups' needs are known but unsupported. Providing keys for self-help, building personal confidence and logic or outside-the-box thinking, as well as improving their community-building skills through games could facilitate such processes. Indeed, play provides fundamental skills to better face complex life challenges: administrative tasks, integration in a community, making one's skills be valued, etc.

Thirdly, the benefits could be observed through time. On the short-term, they could increase harmony and personal wellbeing in community centres, asylums, etc. On the medium-term, individuals could enjoy a smoother integration in broader society. On the long-term, it could lower personal suffering, feelings of alienation, and even criminality rates. For all these

reasons, the ITN framework shows the high societal relevance of this project, while highlighting its feasibility and potential impact.

The project is tripartite: to learn, create and test a few prototypes of games. The first month of the fellowship will be dedicated to assimilating (1) educative games theory, (2) history of collaborative games, (3) what are the needs and challenges of neglected groups, and (4) how to integrate ludic and engaging mechanics into play, based on universally beloved games.

Then, the objective for the second and third month is to imagine a variety of games that follow the principles found in the first part. They might be distinct based on groups' needs, interests, but also show adaptability based on cognitive, linguistic and physical capacity. Indeed, the aim is inclusivity, there must be at least one game accessible to every individual, no matter if they are ADHD, if they do not speak the language of their peers, or if they need mobility aids, for instance.

Finally, from the fourth to the sixth months, the trying, updating and assessing of the games begin. In Caputh, Potsdam and Berlin: local schools, homeless shelters and universities might be the most accessible “testing” grounds. Primary schools emulate young kids' attention span and misbehaviour/cheating in games. Homeless shelters or support organisations welcome varied crowds and propose regular activities or have at least weekly gatherings in which cheerful activities foster feelings of dignity and empowerment. Despite university students representing relatively privileged groups, universities have many advantages. They provide a neutral testing area, many willing subjects for social experiments, and educated constructive feedback on the experience. This moment is the crucial step to check applicability to varied crowds, the ludic potential of games and witnessing short-term outcomes. It will impulse a three-months long feedback loop for improvement of the games and playing “rules” or aims.

Success would be seen as improving induction and deduction skills in youth primarily, as well as an increased capacity at questioning assumptions in adults. It could be tested by pre-and post-screening via individual interviews. Overall harmony or community-building would be observed longitudinally by teachers, caretakers and volunteers who are familiar with the behaviours and in-group dynamics.

There are multiple expected outcomes from this project. Surveys and roundtables will be carried out during testing, which can participate to the edition and publishing of an academic research paper or ethnographic-like report, to further the scientific debate on the impact of play on behavioural development. More particularly, orienting game design principles for marginalized groups. For grassroots, local social impact, news and media could be proposed to cover visits and trials of the game in articles or mini-series, which could spark the interest of movements or policymakers for proactive and positive civic engagement locally. Less likely, if a game is remarkably engaging and fits the INT framework, the final game design could be officialised and its playbook open-sourced to reach European crowds or even become eligible for prizes, to enhance scalability.